It was different for me. I had to keep going, to make sure I didn't say or do anything that I'd regret later. I was a professional soccer player, with responsibilities to myself and to the club. I needed to behave like one, not make things worse.

When I found out the starting eleven, frustration made way for disbelief. Ole Gunnar Solskjaer had done really well playing in my place off and on during the season. If I stepped back from my own disappointment for a moment, I could understand the manager picking him ahead of me. Which of us would be the best choice to start against Madrid came down to a matter of opinion and it would be a manager's job to make the judgement. I could see, after how he'd been playing, it would be hard to leave Ole out. He's been so patient in his time at United, game after game as a sub. No-one could say Ole hadn't earned his chance. What I couldn't believe—and what made me sure that the manager was leaving me out for personal rather than soccer reasons—was seeing Juan Sebastien Veron's name on the teamsheet. Don't get me wrong. Seba and I get on really well and I think he's a marvelous player. I'd never resent him getting a game ahead of me. But what was the boss thinking? Seba had been out injured for seven weeks. He'd trained for just a couple of days: hadn't even been fit enough to be a sub against Blackburn four days before. But, for the biggest game of the season, he was in ahead of me. Nine months of what felt like hard knocks and, now, the hardest of the lot. I was shatterd by it: my soccer world snatched from under my feet.

I went in and got changed without saying anything to anybody. Most of the other lads were already heading off to have lunch. I went out to the car. I had to let Tony Stephens know what had happened: it felt to me as if this was something that would make staying at United more difficult. For the first time in my life, I wondered if playing soccer somewhere else might be better than playing it here. I needed to let someone know how upset and angry I was. Tony couldn't believe what I had to tell him. He said that trying to behave as if everything was fine was the right thing to do: sit on the bench and be ready when I got the chance. He was sure this could all still be an opportunity for me. I can't say I was as confident as Tony sounded but talking to him calmed me down a bit at least. I rang Victoria.

You look to your wife for support and what do you get? From Victoria, I always seem to get just what I need. It was another of those times when the pressure was becoming that intense I wasn't sure I knew how to handle it. Like during the build-up to the game against Argentina in Sapporo. Since that boot had hit me, my situation and my future had been talked and written about to the point where I was getting suffocated by it all. You know you're in